

BETTER SAFE THAN SORRY
Covid testing at a railway station in Mumbai, Dec. 29

AFTER NEARLY FIVE MONTHS OF being able to travel freely at all hours, residents in Delhi now have to make peace with a new night curfew. The national capital reported 331 new Covid cases on December 27, the highest single-day rise since June 9. The figure was nearly 10 times higher than the number of fresh cases reported on December 1. Keeping the surge in mind, the Delhi government joined neighbouring Haryana and Uttar Pradesh in imposing a night curfew. Even though Delhi's test positivity rate is only 0.68 per cent, well below the WHO (World Health Organization) recommendation of 5 per cent or lower, officials are erring on the side of caution as the new highly infectious Covid variant, Omicron, has already been detected in at least 165 cases in the state, as on December 28.

India had logged 653 Omicron cases across 21 states and Union territories till December 28, of which 186 patients had recovered or migrated, according to the ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW). Maharashtra recorded the maximum cases (167), followed by Delhi (165), Kerala (57), Telangana (55), Gujarat (49) and Rajasthan (46). As seen with the second wave caused by the Delta variant earlier this year, any sustained rise in Covid cases is a warning of an oncoming surge. "We shouldn't wait for things to get as bad as they are abroad, particularly in the UK. Omicron has caused major surges globally and we must be prepared to stop a similar situation in India," says Dr Randeep Guleria, director, AIIMS, New Delhi.

Omicron, or the B.1.1.529 variant, which was first reported in late November in South Africa, is fast replacing Delta globally. As on December 28, it had spread to 108 countries and caused 151,000 infections and 26 deaths. The variant, which has eight more mutations in its receptor binding domain (the part the virus uses to enter human cells) than Delta, has a doubling time of 1.5-3 days. Household and contact studies in the UK confirm it to be the most infectious Covid strain to date. "The next few weeks will give us a clear picture of Omicron's spread in India," says Dr Sandeep Budhiraja, group medical director, Max Healthcare. "It has replaced the older strains in several countries and will behave no differently in India."

On a national scale, there are no indicators of a rapid spread yet. As on December 27, India's R-value (the number of people a Covid patient can infect) was below 1, indicating slow transmission, while the national test positivity rate was 0.98 per cent. About 20 districts, though, had a weekly positivity rate of over 5 per cent. These were in Kerala, Mizoram, Sikkim, Manipur and West Bengal. The R-value in some metros is also a cause for concern. As on December 15, Delhi had the highest R-value of 1.12, followed by Mumbai (1.10), Bengaluru (1.07), Kolkata (1.05) and Chennai (1.04).

HALTING A POTENTIAL WAVE

Some studies suggest the virus has already spread enough to trigger a third national wave. An IIT Kanpur study, uses a statistical tool called the Gaussian Mixture model, predicts early February to be the peak of the third wave. There are also predictions based on global examples about how bad the wave can get. France, despite 81 per cent vaccination coverage, clocked 100,000 new cases on December 28. "A similar outbreak in India,

IS A THIRD WAVE IMMINENT?

NATIONALLY, NO SIGN YET OF A NEW SURGE...

↘ India's R-value stays below 1, indicating transmission is slow, and the test positivity rate was 0.98% on December 27.

...BUT POCKETS OF CONCERN ARE EMERGING

↘ There are 20 districts with a weekly positivity rate of over 5%. These districts are in Kerala, Mizoram, Sikkim, Manipur and West Bengal.

↘ R-value in some metros shows rising transmission. As on December 15, Delhi had the highest R-value (1.12) followed by Mumbai (1.10), Bengaluru (1.07), Kolkata (1.05) and Chennai (1.04).

↘ On December 27, Delhi had the highest single-day surge (331 cases) since June 9.